Pactrack: Humphrey, Shaun, Owen
Professor Prioleau
P2 – User Research
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Link to our website: https://shaunbaek.github.io/packtrack/

Section 1

Interview Plan

Who will you be interviewing?
- We will aim to interview 4 aspiring gym-goers and 2 frequent gym-goers.

Why did you choose them?
- The main idea behind PackTrack was to lower the barrier to working out at the Woodpec, given its density during peak hours and the mix of emotions that comes with that. However, both aspiring gym goers and regulars can benefit from our future solution, as they ultimately share a part of the problem space.

Where and when will the interview take place?
- We will interview people at the Woodpec at various times.

How were the interviews conducted?
- Each interview lasted approx. 15-20 minutes; two team members attended each session (one leading the questions while the other took detailed notes).
- Prior to interviews, we observed the WoodPEC during peak hours (4-7 pm) to understand common behaviors, such as students walking the hallway to check equipment availability and groups waiting near basketball courts.

What questions will you ask?
- See the Interview Guide

What do you hope to learn?
- We hope to gain a deeper understanding of what motivates people to go/not go to the Woodpec. Are crowds that affect one's workout? Is it accessibility? Do people want to work out alone or with someone else? We are very curious to hear what people have to say in order to create a relevant solution to all the people in our problem space.

Interview Guide:

Context and Background Information

In this interview, we will be exploring how gym users experience crowdedness at the gym, how it affects their workouts, and how they currently make decisions about when to go. The goal is to understand frustrations, behaviors, and unmet needs related to gym occupancy and space availability.

Opening / Warm-up Questions

1. Can you walk me through your typical gym routine if you do go to the gym?
2. If you do not go to the gym, walk me through what is stopping you.

Core Questions

3. Tell me about a time when the gym felt too crowded for you.

    a. What happened?
    b. How did it affect your workout or motivation?\
4. Do you usually expect the gym to be crowded or empty when you go? Why or why not?
5. What factors influence your expectations (time of day, day of week, school/work schedule)?
6. How do you currently figure out whether the gym is packed before going?
    a. Do you ask friends, or just guess?
7. How does gym crowdedness affect how you feel about working out?
8. Think about times when you skipped the gym. Why did you decide not to go?
    a. Was crowding part of that decision?
9. If there were an app that showed how busy the gym is in real time, how would you use it?
10. What features would make it useful or not useful?

Closing Question

11. If you could redesign how people find out how busy the gym is, what would the ideal experience look like?

Description of the Interviews:

ID	Name	Classification	Major	Description
1	Jeremiah J	Senior	Business: Marketing	22-year-old male from New York City. Ambivert. Frequent gym-goer.
2	Muhammed D	Senior	Business: Finance	22-year-old male from New York City. Extreme extrovert. Comfortable in changing spaces. Inconsistent gym-goers become frequent at spaces in time.
3	David G	Senior	Psychology	22-year old male from Florida, very introverted. Sparsely goes to the SAAC.
4	Tsiky A	Senior	Human Health	21-year old female from Georgia. Frequent-gym goer, introvert, cat-lover.
5	Brian K	Senior	Computer Science	21-year-old male from Orange County, CA. Introvert. Infrequent gym-goer who prefers outdoor activities like hiking and basketball.
6	Christian S	Senior	Business: Strategy and Management Consulting	21-year-old male from Fort Lee, New Jersey. Extrovert. Frequent gym-goer who works out with friends.

3) **Data from needfinding interviews:**

Empathy map:

Gym Goers

Feels

- Annoyed when it is full, and has to switch out workout routine. (owen.tucker)
- Stressed when the gym is packed. (owen.tucker)
- Values the social aspect of working out. (owen.tucker)
- Confident in his gym knowledge, but still affected by Woodpec's limitations (owen.tucker)
- Rushed and pressured from others are waiting for equipment (owen.tucker)
- People go to the Woodpec at packed hours even though it can be frustrating (owen.tucker)

Does

- Goes to the gym frequently (owen.tucker)
- Tries to avoid peak hours after bad experiences (owen.tucker)
- Waits 15+ minutes for equipment when gym is crowded (owen.tucker)
- Pays for LA Fitness membership despite having 'free' access to Woodpec (owen.tucker)
- Only uses Woodpec for basketball, avoids weight room entirely. (owen.tucker)
- Checks in with friends before going to the Woodpec (owen.tucker)

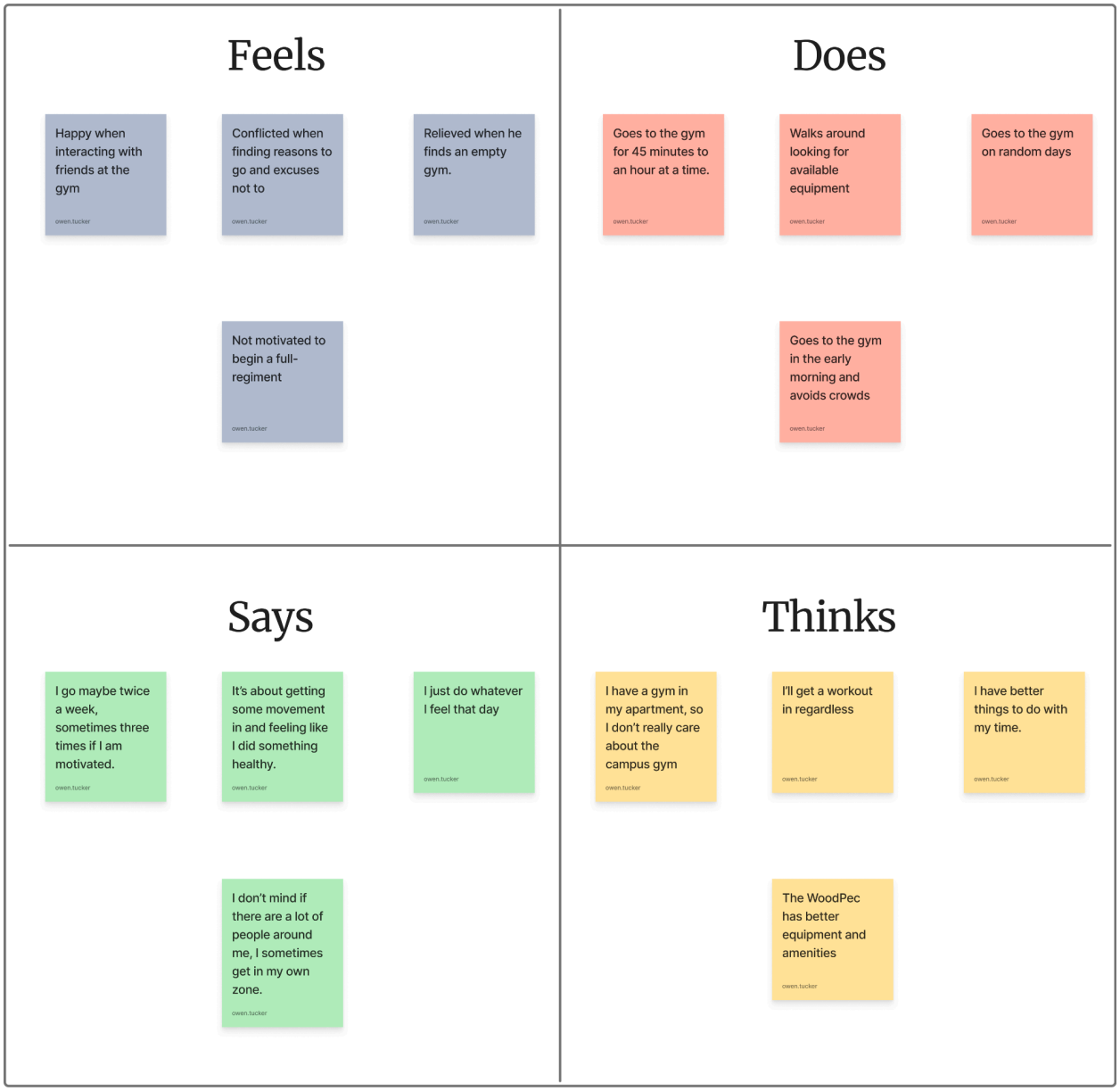
Says

- I wish there was a way to see how crowded the gym is. (owen.tucker)
- There's always people curling in the squat rack (owen.tucker)
- It threw off my whole workout, I just did legs instead (owen.tucker)
- Feels like everyone knows what they are doing besides me (owen.tucker)
- I've never gone back to lift there (owen.tucker)
- I go about 5 times a week, usually in the evening around 6:30pm (owen.tucker)

Thinks

- I don't like going to crowded gyms (owen.tucker)
- Basketball court scheduling is unpredictable despite being 'scheduled' (owen.tucker)
- I want more transparency about what's available real-time (owen.tucker)
- LA Fitness is worth the money and the commute (owen.tucker)
- Woodpec could be better (owen.tucker)
- The gym is always crowded, so why bother checking (owen.tucker)

Aspiring Gym Goers



Inferences

We also made a list of tensions, surprises, and contradictions across our 6 interviewees that summarizes some of our conclusions and things that intrigued us:

Tensions	Surprises	Contradictions
TA - There is some underlying tension when going to the gym and not knowing if it is packed or not,	TA - The structural layout of the Woodpec is a factor that dissuades people from going to the gym, as you have	TA - Even though going to the gym at a busy hour can be frustrating and impact the quality of a workout, many

especially because this can affect the way someone works out.	to walk up and down the hallway to figure out if a machine is taken. - A gym app that measures the capacity at any given moment has been implemented successfully, which improved the gym experience.	people seem to go at the busiest time of the day regardless.
Jeremiah J - Mentions that the only time he can fit time to go to the gym during his class schedule is during “peak-hours,” which is a conflict he mentions a lot of friends face, and what leads to the gym being at a high capacity.	Jeremiah J - Surprised that someone could just skip the gym after arriving just because of how “crowded” it is, and always prioritizes his “gains” no matter how inconvenient the environment is.	Jeremiah J - Considers himself a consistent gym goer, but has expressed "annoyance" with how crowded the gym can become during peak hours, but instead of trying the SAAC gym choose to continue to use the WoodPec due to other amenities
Muhammed D - Wants to establish a more consistent gym routine but lacks the time to pursue that consistency. - Has a gym at his apartment complex and wrestles with the need to go to WoodPec even though the facility has more amenities.	Muhammed D - Says he is surprised that the gym crowding is a problem, and he looks at it as a way to meet more people and interact.	Muhammed D - Says he goes to the gym 2-3 times per week "if feeling motivated," but crowding is not actively de-motivating him to go.
David G.’ - Is stuck between wanting to go to the gym more often and not, only making the trip a few times every month. When he does go, there usually aren’t crowds, as he likes going in the early morning.	David G. - He explained that his barrier to entry for becoming more consistent at the gym wasn’t as much the crowds or a sense of pressure, but more a lack of his own motivation, and the fact that he rather be doing other things.	David G. - Says he wants to do more weightlifting, especially with friends, yet never has recalled a time when he asked a friend to go to the gym with him. - For someone who said they were very ‘scheduled-oriented’, the times he does go

		to the gym are random. - Although he says that crowds are not an issue, he will skip days he planned on going if they end up being in the afternoon due to work or classes.
Brian K. - There's tension between wanting to be healthier and the social anxiety of going to a crowded gym where he feels like he doesn't belong. - The 10-minute walk creates a mental barrier - it's not just about the gym being crowded, but about the "sunk cost" of the commute if it turns out to be packed.	Brian K. - Surprised that his avoidance strategy is mostly based on assumptions rather than actual information - he rarely actually checks if it's crowded. - The gym intimidation isn't about fitness level - it's about not knowing the "unwritten rules" of gym etiquette and feeling visible when uncertain.	Brian K. - Even though he's a CS major who would likely appreciate a tech solution, his current "system" is just texting his roommate - very low-tech for someone in his field. - He says he "doesn't have a routine" but actually has very specific preferences (treadmill, basic machines) that suggest he does know what he wants to do - just not confident doing it around others.
Christian S. - There's tension between the convenience of a free on-campus gym and the quality/experience of an off-campus paid gym - convenience loses. - For basketball, the social coordination aspect creates tension - getting 4-5 friends' schedules aligned only to find courts unavailable is uniquely frustrating.	Christian S. - Surprised that someone who works out daily has essentially written off the campus gym entirely based on one bad experience freshman year. - The basketball court problem is different from the weight room problem - it's not about crowding but about scheduled events (intramurals, clubs) that aren't clearly communicated.	Christian S. - Claims to be a "frequent gym-goer" but doesn't actually use the gym that's 2 minutes from his dorm - his gym routine requires a 15-minute drive. - Uses a group chat system for basketball that works reasonably well, but never thought to apply similar coordination for weight room visits.

Summary

What was discovered from our interviews was that a core deterrent to gym attendance is an information gap. It is the anxiety that a person feels when they cannot determine if the gym is packed or if this is going to be a “good” environment to work in. For students facing a commute to the gym that ranges from 10 to 20 minutes, the uncertainty of whether they will have to change their entire workout schedule due to overcrowding at the gym leads them into a real dilemma. In addition to the physical layout of the gym, students are often forced to scavenge for equipment, which can heighten social anxiety. Rather than just being an availability issue, students want to bridge the gap and determine the gym's availability before leaving their dorm room, which removes the mental burden of the commute and aimless searching for equipment to use.

Furthermore, a peak hour paradox exists where users are structurally locked into crowded windows by their academic schedules, removing the chances to redistribute traffic to off-peak hours. This suggests that the solution should not focus on emptying the gym, but on optimizing the experience *during* peak congestion. By improving the communication of court schedules and facilitating better machine-sharing flows, the university can mitigate the drop in students who currently seek expensive, off-campus alternatives.

Section 2:

POV statements:

We met Tsiky A., a 26’ Human Health major from Georgia. We were interested to learn that she had used an app for Planet Fitness that tracked the gym's activity at any given time. It would be impactful to not only have a similar approach for the Woodpec, but also have more app-based solutions for other areas of the Woodpec, like reserving tennis courts or other equipment.

We met Jeremiah J., a senior majoring in Business and Marketing. We were interested to learn that despite being a consistent gym-goer who prioritizes himself, he faces a scheduling conflict that many other students share: the only time he can fit workouts into his academic schedule is during peak hours, which is exactly what creates the overcrowding problem. His commitment is so strong that he refuses to skip workouts even in frustrating conditions, but he's expressed “annoyance” with peak-hour crowds. It would be amazing to provide crowd information and suggest alternative time slots.

We met Muhammad D., a senior majoring in Finance from New York City. We were interested to learn that, unlike most occasional gym users, he doesn't view crowding as a negative barrier to attendance. Instead, he sees it as an opportunity to meet people and interact socially. He described it as a powerful tool he used freshman year to make friends. However, his inconsistent 2-3 times-per-week routine isn't driven by a lack of motivation from crowds, but rather by genuine time constraints and a decision about whether to use the gym at his apartment complex or make the trip to WoodPec for better amenities. It would be impactful to create a tool that helps him maximize his limited gym time by quickly comparing real-time conditions at both his apartment gym and WoodPec.

We met David G, a senior majoring in Psychology from Florida. He describes himself as an extreme introvert, yet explained that his main deterrent in going to the gym isn't crowds or a lack of machines, but a lack of interest. This was unlike a majority of our interviewees who were pushed back more due to the crowd and constrained environment in the Woodpec. He goes to the SAAC on the Clairemont campus a few times a month and doesn't feel like the Woodpec is worth it, as his preferred exercise is walking on the treadmill. However, he notes that the Woodpec has much better equipment for his goals. It would be impactful to make the Woodpec feel more worth it when aspiring to one's goals.

We met Brian K., a '26 Computer Science major from Orange County, CA. We were interested to learn that his biggest barrier to the gym isn't laziness or lack of interest; it's the uncertainty of whether the trip will be "worth it." The 10-minute walk to WoodPEC feels like a gamble, and when he arrives to find it packed, he often just leaves without working out. His current solution is texting his roommate to ask, "Is it bad?" It would be impactful to provide real-time crowd information that gives infrequent gym-goers like Brian the confidence to actually make the trip, reducing the mental barrier that comes with uncertainty.

We met Christian S., a '26 Business Strategy major from Fort Lee, New Jersey. We were surprised to learn that, despite being a daily gym-goer, he's essentially written off the WoodPEC entirely for weight training - paying for an LA Fitness membership instead of using the free campus facility. His one exception is basketball, where coordinating with friends only to find courts unavailable is uniquely frustrating since it wastes everyone's aligned schedules. It would be impactful to provide not just crowd levels but specific facility information - like which courts are available for open gym vs. reserved for intramurals - so groups can make informed decisions before committing to plans.

HMW statements:

- How might we create a platform that connects gym-goers to one another?
- How might we reduce frustration and anxiety around going to the gym from lack of information on how full it is?
- How might we create a platform that informs users on the capacity of the gym?
- How might we encourage gym-goers to work together when doing sets?
- How might we create a low-pressure environment for aspiring gym-goers?
- How might we make the Woodpec feel more 'worth it'?
- How might we provide clearer scheduling for students wanting to use spaces?
- How might we lower the mental barrier of entry for aspiring gym-goers?
- How might we eliminate the gambling aspect of going to the Woodpec in terms of crowds?
- How might we make Woodpec a more viable choice for both aspiring and long-time gym-goers?

Needs Identified:

Based on the interview, we identified the following core user needs:

1. Information Before Commitment – Students need to know gym crowding levels before making the trip, eliminating the "gamble" of whether the commute will be worth it.
2. Specific Availability Visibility – Students need to see which specific equipment, machines, or courts are available (not just overall gym capacity).

3. Predictability Around Peak Hours – Students locked into peak-hour schedules need better ways to plan around crowding rather than simply avoiding it.
4. Lower Social Pressure for Beginners – Aspiring gym-goers need a way to enter the gym environment without feeling watched or judged for not knowing "the rules."
5. Real-Time Court Scheduling – Groups coordinating basketball need accurate, real-time information about court availability vs. intramural/club reservations.
6. Reduced Mental Barrier – Infrequent gym-goers need the uncertainty removed so the decision to go becomes easier than the decision to skip.